with estimates that at least twenty-five per cent of many people's income is donated to non-state institutions in the absence of any operable income tax.[13] When asked what specific help the government provides them, they struggle to give an example — and eventually point to the electricity grid they were connected to two years before and for which they pay around 4000 kyat (US$3.1) per month.[14]

They do not read newspapers, and get most of their information through discussions with neighbours and, to a lesser extent, television. One family member does have Facebook, courtesy of a recently purchased smartphone, though reception in the village drops out regularly. Local monasteries, the social welfare groups affiliated with them, and the social events framed and lubricated by Buddhist spirituality thus form the major networks through which they encounter information about party politics and the ongoing transition.

With regard to politics, the family repeats many of the same opinions heard in Taungoo's urban core as well as surrounding villages, which recent nationally representative surveys of political attitudes bear out as well.[15] They have a positive evaluation of Aung San Suu Kyi, who they believe has a compassionate mind and, to a slightly less extent, praise former President Thein Sein as a reformer. They are deeply concerned about the status of Buddhism in Myanmar. Seated in front of a vinyl poster erected in their house advertising a meditation event held in the village in 2014, they discussed the issue of immigration to Myanmar, especially what they refer to as the arrival of 'Muslim Bengalis' from Bangladesh.

They are not involved in a political party and, until the political campaign commenced in September 2015, they didn't know if there were any political parties active in their village. Even in the week prior to the November 8 election, they remained undecided about which party they would support, as they were reluctant to express their aspirations or to make a choice that could offend their local headman. After months of vacillation, however, when I visited them in the days following the poll, they proudly showed their indelibly stained pinky fingers and declared they had "voted for change!"

When we discussed what they hoped would change with an NLD government, they were unsure. "Hopefully business gets better now", the father suggested, mentioning that relations with America and Europe may improve. "Maybe the NLD government will cooperate more with the welfare groups", the matriarch said. "We need so many permission